

Since the Law of the People's Republic of China on Safeguarding National Security in the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region came into effect on July 1, 2020, media reports have highlighted that Hong Kong Public Libraries and school libraries have removed numerous books and periodicals from their shelves. Concurrently, the Correctional Services Department (CSD) has designated specific books and publications as banned materials. Following complaints and reports from certain organizations alleging that some literature violated the national security law, several distributors and publishers have been convicted and sentenced to imprisonment.

As of July 13, 2026, no fewer than 600 titles are reported to have been banned, censored, or subjected to complaints.

Policy and Environment Prior to 2020

On October 2, 2007, the Leisure and Cultural Services Department (LCSD) clarified the acquisition policy of public libraries, stating:

"Hong Kong Public Libraries selects and purchases library materials in accordance with the principles of the UNESCO Public Library Manifesto to meet the needs of different people in the society for lifelong learning, academic research, access to information and the best use of spare time. In the spirit of the Manifesto, the Hong Kong Public Libraries adheres to the principle of safeguarding information freedom when purchasing books and newspapers and will not censor publications."

On June 24, 2009, the Home Affairs Department stated in the Legislative Council of the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region:

"As at June 15, 2009, the Hong Kong Public Libraries (HKPL) holds 149 titles of books on the 1989 Tiananmen Square protests and massacre and related topics and the number of copies

totals 1,162. In response to the demand of the readers, HKPL has ordered an addition of 250 copies of these books. By then, the percentage of the relevant books available for loan will be 82%."

Despite having 149 such titles in 2009, by May 2023, only three titles related to the event remained in the public library collection.

The A Concise History of Hong Kong abridged edition incident (2013)

In 2013, it was revealed that historian John M. Carroll's book *A Concise History of Hong Kong* existed in both an "original version" and an abridged Chinese edition. While the covers, translators, and publishing details of both versions were largely identical, the abridged version omitted numerous paragraphs concerning the Chinese government and Hong Kong politics. Carroll stated that he had no prior knowledge of the abridged version's existence, expressed shock and disappointment, and demanded that the publisher recall it.

Chung Hwa Book Company (Hong Kong) Limited, the publisher, responded that the abridged edition was merely a "sample copy" produced for copyright negotiations with mainland China, which leaked into the market due to being mistakenly sent to the Hong Kong Book Fair for sale. However, media reports pointed out that the abridged version had also been sold in other bookstores across Hong Kong, conflicting with the publisher's account. The incident sparked widespread public discussion regarding whether the publisher altered content due to political factors and raised concerns about self-censorship within the publishing industry.

Post-2020 developments

Public Library collection removals and government response

On 4 July 2020, media outlets first reported that several titles in the Hong Kong Public Libraries (HKPL) collections had been removed from shelves following the enactment of the National Security Law. An investigation by Stand News revealed that the Leisure and Cultural

Services Department (LCSD) had issued directives to "review" works by certain pro-democracy political figures and columnists, including Joshua Wong (Huang, Zhifeng.), Tanya Chan (Chen, Shuzhuang.), and Chin Wan (Chen, Yun.). The books were suspended from circulation and removed from public shelves while the review was pending.

The LCSD subsequently responded that since the implementation of the law in late June 2020, public libraries had incorporated the safeguarding of national security as a key consideration in acquiring books and accepting donations. The department added that it would review materials upon receiving public complaints, implementing suspensions or removals as necessary. While authorities emphasized that any books suspected of violating local legislations would be immediately taken down for review, they consistently declined to disclose specific figures or a checklist of the removed titles.

Following a report by the Audit Commission urging stronger vetting procedures, the LCSD stated it had completed the removal of books "manifestly contrary to national security." The department revealed that the comprehensive assessment of its collections commenced in 2021. However, due to the growing volume of books requiring inspection and the complexity of the follow-up work, the review remained incomplete as of the first quarter of 2023. Consequently, the LCSD stated it was "impossible to set a definitive completion date" for the entire vetting process.

On May 16, 2023, Chief Executive John Lee Ka-chiu responded to the controversy surrounding the Leisure and Cultural Services Department (LCSD) removing a large number of public library books from its shelves. He emphasized that the LCSD has a responsibility to ensure that borrowed books serve Hong Kong's interests and do not violate Hong Kong law, which includes reviewing whether books disseminate information detrimental to Hong Kong or involve copyright issues. He stated that he has confidence in the professional judgment of the department's staff, and added that if citizens wish to read these books, they can still purchase them through private bookstores.

Criticisms and international response

Some scholars argue that the government's current library policies violate the UNESCO Public Library Manifesto, which asserts that "collections and services should not be subject to any form of ideological, political or religious censorship, nor commercial pressures." Critics have expressed concern that these measures undermine the fundamental role of public libraries.

On November 11, 2022, the United Nations Human Rights Committee issued its "Concluding observations on the fourth periodic report of Hong Kong, China," evaluating the region's compliance with the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights. In Article C, Paragraph 44, the Committee recommended that Hong Kong should:

- (a) Immediately stop censoring books and other material in public libraries, including school libraries, and reinstate the books and other material that have been removed for allegedly breaching the National Security Law or for being contrary to the interests of national security;
- (b) Publish a list of the books and materials that have been removed;
- (c) Take concrete steps necessary to ensure non-recurrence.

To date, the Hong Kong government and school management bodies have not implemented these recommendations. Observers argue this lack of compliance conflicts with the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and associated international treaties.

On July 30, 2026, Choi Chi-sum, general secretary of the Society for Truth and Light, commented on bookstores in Hong Kong facing obstruction for selling books that have not been ruled illegal by a court, emphasizing that reading books from diverse perspectives is vital for building critical thinking and strengthening convictions. He pointed out that bookstore staff and owners cannot possibly read every single line of every book, making it completely normal to sell books not yet ruled illegal, and noted that Hong Kong has never had a prior censorship system for newspapers and publications, which is the true embodiment of

freedom of speech and publication. He believes that under "One Country, Two Systems," Hong Kong's bottom line lies in freedom of speech and publication, meaning citizens should not live in fear of possessing unconvicted books, and business operations require clear legal bases rather than relying solely on officials' subjective views. Choi reiterated that if law enforcement agencies believe someone has broken the law, they must publicly disclose the reasons for prosecution and must never arrest, seize, or ban sales based on unwarranted charges or undisclosed reasoning, as doing so would constitute an abuse of power and undermine the rule of law, given that the purpose of the law is to provide citizens with predictable rules and restrain government behavior rather than suppress dissidents.

School library restrictions and self-censorship

In 2024, reports emerged that school administrators and educators responsible for national security education had escalated self-censorship efforts. Books published in Taiwan became a primary focus due to printed terms such as "Taiwan," "Country," or "National Library Cataloging in Publication." Schools adopted various containment measures, including using stickers or black markers to cover up the terms "Taiwan" and "country," or removing Taiwan-published books entirely from library shelves.

These developments parallel earlier actions in 2023, where the Hong Kong Government and the Liaison Office of the Central People's Government of China barred Taiwanese universities from using the term "national" during the Taiwan Education Exhibition in Hong Kong, leading some institutions to withdraw from the event. Such practices have been described as similar to earlier censorship methods used by mainland China to remove politically sensitive terms, such as the "Republic of China calendar era" (Minguo era), from Taiwanese books.

Additionally, reports indicate that some government schools in Hong Kong have discontinued the use of the HyRead e-book platform, provided by Taiwan's Hyweb Technology. Furthermore, they have canceled certain online reading platforms for Chinese and English

subjects to prevent teachers and students from accessing content alleged to violate the National Security Law or the Basic Law.

Inaction by library professional associations

Beyond the high volume of books and periodicals actively removed from libraries, numerous other publications have never reached shelves due to preemptive censorship or self-censorship. Critics argue this silently deprives readers of information freedom.

During this period, major local library associations, such as the Hong Kong Library Association and the Hong Kong Teacher-Librarians' Association, did not issue public concerns or take collective professional action. This lack of response has been described by some as a collapse of professional standards. Observers note that local librarians, teacher-librarians, school quality-assurance personnel (inspectors) of the Education Bureau, school management, and teachers have struggled to uphold established codes of professionalism and safeguard the free flow of information.

Additionally, literature regarding the 1989 Tiananmen Square protests and massacre has become increasingly scarce across libraries and mainstream retail bookstores in Hong Kong.

Government response and blacklist controversy

In response to repeated calls from the public and the publishing industry to release an official list of banned books, the Hong Kong government has consistently declined to do so.

Following law enforcement actions involving independent bookstores, including "Book Punch" in April 2026, as well as "Have A Nice Stay" and "Greenfield Bookstore" in July 2026, Secretary for Security Chris Tang Ping-keung reiterated the government's stance during media briefings. Tang maintained that establishing a "blacklist" would "facilitate lawbreakers" by allowing them to circumvent regulations, suggesting that offenders might exploit loopholes simply by changing book titles to evade liability. He emphasized that law enforcement focuses on

whether the underlying content harbors seditious intent, such as inciting hatred against the government or the judiciary, rather than the titles themselves, asserting that "the law is very clear; if you break the law, you have crossed the red line."

Tang further argued that booksellers bear an inherent responsibility to vet their inventory to ensure compliance with national security laws, drawing a parallel to the catering industry:

"If you sell food, you make sure that the food you sell won't give people stomach aches, isn't poisonous, and isn't illegal. I believe that booksellers, likewise, have a responsibility [to ensure that their books do not endanger national security]."

Expanding on the analogy, Tang noted that while food merchants might not personally taste every product, they retain methods to verify sources and ingredients. Consequently, he stated it is implausible for bookstore owners to sell literature without any knowledge of its contents, concluding that claiming not to have opened or read a book does not constitute a valid legal defense.

Independent publishers and bookstore closures

Book Fair exclusions

Independent publishers participating in the Hong Kong Book Fair have encountered rising levels of censorship. At least three independent publishers, including "Bbluesky" (藍藍的天) and "Boundary Bookstore" (界限書店), were denied exhibition booths at the 2025 Hong Kong Book Fair. The publishers linked this rejection to their refusal to withdraw "sensitive" books from their displays during the previous year's event. Although the publishers maintained their books were legal and appropriate, the organizer, the Hong Kong Trade Development Council (HKTDC), declined their applications without providing specific reasons, leading to public concern over freedom of publication.

On June 29, 2026, two prominent local independent bookstores, "Elmbook" (榆林書店, est.

1997) and "Luckwin Bookstore" (樂文書店, est. 1984), were disqualified from participating in the 2026 Hong Kong Book Fair, marking their first rejection as regular exhibitors. Both bookstores declined to comment in detail. The HKTDC defended its decision by stating it maintains "sole and absolute discretion" over admission without the need to provide explanations.

This occurred despite statement by HKTDC Deputy Executive Director Sophia Chong earlier that month asserting they "would not censor booksellers." Commentators noted that both bookstores had previously been criticized by pro-Beijing media such as Wen Wei Po for selling books deemed to be of "soft resistance" or in alleged violation of the National Security Law, including the former Hong Kong Governor Chris Patten's memoir, *The Hong Kong Diaries*.

At the 2026 Hong Kong Book Fair, several books and literary magazines from Book Matter (本事出版) were ordered to be removed from the shelves, leaving their booth with no books on display or for sale.

Having operated for 29 years, "Elmbook" announced via social media on July 8 that it will close its physical store after its lease expires in April 2027, following the rejection of its book fair application (commonly known as "DQ").

National Security raids and arrests

In early-to-mid 2026, the National Security Department carried out several high-profile enforcement operations targeting independent booksellers:

March 24, 2026: Police raided the independent bookstore "Book Punch" (一拳書館), arresting its founder Pong Yat-ming (龐一鳴) and three staff members. They were accused of selling "seditious publications," which included *The Troublemaker*, a biography of jailed media tycoon Jimmy Lai. This was the first enforcement action against a retail bookstore under Section 24 of the Safeguarding National Security Ordinance.

June 24, 2026: Authorities searched "Hunter Bookstore" (獵人書店) in Mong Kok and arrested its operators, including former pro-democracy district councillor Wong Man-huen (黃文萱). The operators were accused of committing "acts with seditious intention" under the Safeguarding National Security Ordinance, along with "money laundering" allegations involving foreign funds. Seized books included copies of *The Troublemaker*, a biography of jailed media tycoon Jimmy Lai and cartoon compilations by political satirist Zunzi. International human rights organizations criticized the operations as damaging to the Hong Kong's atmosphere of openness and intellectual diversity.

July 15, 2026: On the opening day of the 36th Hong Kong Book Fair, a joint operation by the National Security Department and the Customs and Excise Department was conducted at "Have A Nice Stay" (留下書舍) in Prince Edward and "Greenfield Book Store" (田園書屋) in Mong Kok. Five people were arrested for alleged seditious acts. "Have A Nice Stay" (founded by former journalists) had announced the previous day that it would shut down on August 30 due to financial strain and the prevailing political climate. Authorities reportedly acted after intercepting an overseas cargo shipment containing *Let only red flowers bloom: identity and belonging in Xi Jinping's China*, published by Taiwan's Acropolis, which was suspected of carrying seditious intent. "Greenfield Book Store" (田園書屋), a long-standing independent bookstore that operated in Hong Kong for 50 years, announced via social media in the early hours of July 29 that it will officially close its doors once its current lease expires. This decision follows a search conducted by officers from the National Security Department of the Hong Kong Police Force and the subsequent arrest of related personnel in mid-July.

The July 2026 raids and arrests drew sharp condemnation from international human rights organizations and regional leaders, who viewed the operations as a severe blow to freedom of expression and independent publishing in Hong Kong. The Committee to Protect Journalists (CPJ) condemned the enforcement of national security legislation against venues managed by former members of the press, classifying it as a direct assault on journalism and calling for the

immediate release of detained freelance journalist Sum Wan-wah and bookstore staff member Mandy Lau. Amnesty International accused Hong Kong authorities of deliberately weaponizing "sedition" offenses to eliminate spaces for free thought and open debate, emphasizing that the ambiguous, shifting legal boundaries surrounding banned literature have intensified self-censorship within the city.

Concurrently, Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te publicly expressed concern on social media over the shrinking sphere for public discourse, describing bookstores as critical spaces for intellectual intersection and the preservation of social memory. He noted that when "books can become criminal evidence and bookstores are forced to repeatedly second-guess invisible red lines," the public can no longer think and express themselves freely. Comparing the political pressure to Taiwan's past martial law era, Lai paid tribute to Hong Kong cultural workers striving to hold their ground under difficult circumstances, emphasizing that thought and words should not be imprisoned due to political pressure, and stating his hope that Hong Kong's diverse voices and fundamental rights would be respected and protected.

Logistics and Supply Chain Censorship

In July 2026, the Taiwan branch of the Hong Kong-headquartered logistics company Jaguar Logistics Co., Ltd. (嘉達國際物流) issued an internal notice announcing that, in order to comply with the Hong Kong National Security Law and mitigate operational risks, it was immediately tightening screening regulations for shipping books from Taiwan to Hong Kong.

The notice explicitly stated that transportation services would be refused for four independent Hong Kong bookstores recently investigated by the National Security Department: "Greenfield Book Store" (田園書屋), "Have A Nice Stay" (留下書舍), "Book Punch" (一拳書館), and "Hunter Bookstore" (獵人書店). It also required other publishers and clients to submit detailed book lists prior to shipment, ensuring no "violating" books were included before arranging delivery.

Although the Hong Kong Security Bureau stated that authorities had not established an

official "banned book list," logistics company staff indicated that items involving national security cases, sensational titles (such as "Let only red flowers bloom: identity and belonging in Xi Jinping's China" and "The Troublemaker, a biography of jailed media tycoon Jimmy Lai"), or books previously pulled from the Hong Kong Book Fair were placed on the restricted shipping list. Staff even suggested that if there were doubts regarding whether a book constituted a banned item, it could be submitted to Xiamen International Book Company Limited (廈門圖書 / 廈門外圖集團有限公司) for review, reasoning that "Hong Kong already belongs to Mainland governance and is considered part of the Mainland region." This approach drew criticism from Taiwan's publishing industry for shifting the burden of self-censorship onto the sector.

Overseas Hong Kong Publishers and Self-Censorship

Beginning in the 2020s, several Hong Kong publishers relocated overseas and established new publishing houses with the aim of upholding freedom of publication and preserving Hong Kong history. Among them is "Gotta Press (應該出版)," established in Taiwan with Deng Xiaohua (Tang Siu-wa) as editor-in-chief, alongside veteran publisher Chen Hui-hui, writers Chen Hui (Chan Wai) and Juanita Cheng (aka Missy Hyper), and lyricist Calvin Poon Yuen-leung serving as president.

In 2025, during the publication of philosopher Cheung Chan-fai's (Zhang Canhui) book *Xi yang xi xia ji shi hui: ji nian lao ming hui de er shi feng xin* (夕陽西下幾時回：給年老明慧的二十封信), the publisher refused to include a foreword written by Chung Kim-wah on the grounds that his "status was sensitive," sparking public skepticism over whether overseas publishers are similarly prone to self-censorship. Subsequently, publications by Gotta Press were reportedly restricted at the Hong Kong Book Fair, prompting the publisher's leadership to publicly state their opposition to book bans and their support for freedom of publication.

Following the incident, Chung Kim-wah publicly criticized the publisher for advocating

freedom of the press and publication on one hand while restricting content out of fear of political risks on the other, questioning whether such actions constituted self-censorship. However, Gotta Press did not publicly state that its decision involved political considerations, leaving the underlying reasons and nature of the publisher's decision open to differing interpretations in public opinion.

List of banned books

This is a dynamic list on books and periodicals that are known to have been censored and/or removed from shelves and/or reported in complaints. This may never be able to satisfy particular standards for completeness. You can help by adding missing items with reliable sources.

See also

Causeway Bay Books disappearances

2020 Hong Kong national security law

Book censorship

Lists of banned books

List of books banned by governments

Censorship in Hong Kong

Internet censorship in Hong Kong

== References ==